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Space Force bets on commercial entrants in \$4B satcom contest

American warfighters need jam-proof communications, and the Space Force is planning to spend hundreds of millions to ensure they have them.

As part of that effort, the service established the Protected Tactical Satcom program to build out secure battlefield communications via satellites. The Space Force has already awarded contracts to defense primes Boeing and Northrop Grumman to develop prototype payloads for satellites heading to far-away geostationary orbit.

Now, the program is entering a new phase. On Tuesday, the Space Force awarded five additional contracts for the design and demonstration of purpose-built satellites to provide jam-resistant comms to tactical forces. The winners include previous winners Boeing, Northrop Grumman, Viasat, and Intelsat, plus a relative newcomer: Astranis, a venture-backed startup based in San Francisco. (Intelsat will buy its satellite bus from K2 Space, another venture-backed startup.)

The initial awards are relatively small, totaling \$37.3 million combined. But the program has a \$4 billion award ceiling, so the winners could sign on to a much more lucrative defense deal.

Each firm will develop its architectures through January 2026. After that, the Space Force will select one design and award an additional contract for the

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first satellite, with a launch planned in 2028.

Additional production awards will be doled out, also in 2028.

The PTS-G contracts are a notable departure from how the military has historically procured geostationary satellites, which have typically had extremely long timelines from contract award to launch, and would cost hundreds of millions to over a billion dollars per spacecraft.

In contrast, the Space Force is clearly trying to leverage the speed of commercial entrants and encourage competition by selecting multiple vendors for the initial phase of the program.

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“Our PTS-G contract transforms how SSC acquires SATCOM capability for the warfighter,” program executive officer Cordell DeLaPena Jr. said in a news release. “The incorporation of commercial baseline designs to meet military capability significantly enhances the Space Force’s speed

and efficiency to add capability to meet emerging threats.”

Topics: [Astranis](#) [Boeing](#) [Government & Policy](#)

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Astranis is contracting
an entire Falcon 9 rocket
to launch four satellites
next year



San Francisco-based startup Astranis has purchased a dedicated launch on a SpaceX Falcon 9 rocket, eschewing the less expensive “ride-share” model favored by new space companies for an exclusive mission that Astranis says will put its package of four communications satellites closer to their target orbit in a much faster amount of time.

“We’re actually using substantially less than the max capability of a Falcon 9,” Astranis CEO and founder John Gedmark explained. “This is just four small satellites that [will be] on the rocket so we’re actually able to use all of that extra performance to put those four satellites much closer to GEO than you would normally be able to do with this kind of launch.”

IMAGE CREDITS: [ASTRANIS](#)

How much faster? At least twice as fast, cutting down the time from up to six months to as little as three months. Purchasing a dedicated launch on a Falcon 9 — a first amongst space companies — also means that Astranis will have much more control over when the rocket takes off and the payload insertion orbit.

Astranis manufactures MicroGEO satellites, so named because they are much smaller and lighter than the typical geostationary communications satellites that are in orbit today, coming in at around 1/20th the size and cost. The geostationary piece is key: while many companies, including SpaceX, are looking to commercialize low-cost satellite internet broadband in low Earth orbit,

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Astranis plans to send its spacecraft to geosynchronous orbit, the band where companies like ViaSat currently operate. Once placed in GEO, each satellite will service one area, following a fixed rotation with the Earth’s surface.



IMAGE CREDITS: [ASTRANIS](#)

“We’re huge fans of what some of these other companies are trying to do with LEO constellations — it’s just a very different approach,” Astranis CEO and founder John Gedmark [told TechCrunch previously](#). “We have the ability to put up one satellite at a time and focus bandwidth right where it’s needed, and do that quickly. The smaller constellations, they are very much an all-or-nothing proposition — the entire constellation has to be in place to begin service. And then they have some other challenges ahead of them as well, like ground antennas, unique tracking.”

Astranis’ first satellite, called Arcturus, will launch on a SpaceX Falcon Heavy ride-share mission sometime this summer. When that satellite enters service later this year, the capacity will be leased exclusively to Alaskan satellite middle-mile provider Pacific Dataport Inc. Astranis said it will triple Alaska’s currently available satellite bandwidth while providing cheaper and more reliable broadband.

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The four satellites that will launch on the Falcon 9 next summer also have dedicated customers: one will deliver broadband internet access to rural Peru in a \$90 million agreement with Latin American telecom company Grupo Andesat; and two will be leased to Anuvu, a company that provides internet connectivity on airplanes and cruises. A separate customer that has yet to be announced will lease the bandwidth from the fourth satellite. The four satellites launching next summer will include a number of technical upgrades, including some upgrades on the radio payload and the propulsion system which will extend the lifespan of the spacecraft.

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As all of these deals illustrate, Astranis' business model is a bit different than other communications satellite operators. Instead of selling directly to consumers (again, à la Starlink), the company leases out bandwidth to communications providers, who then sell the internet connectivity directly to consumers.

“A lot of people are mobile first,” Gedmark said. “They have phones, they have smartphones, and they’re still stuck on 2G internet connections on those phones.” Instead of selling those people internet packages or hardware, Astranis aims for its satellites “to provide extra capacity for cell backhaul,” he said. “By boosting the capacity for cell backhaul, you allow telcos to expand their coverage areas and cell towers out in the most remote places in the entire world.”

The company, which aims to have 100 MicroGEO satellites in orbit by 2030, raised \$250 million in a round led by BlackRock-managed funds and which catapulted its post-money [valuation to \\$1.4 billion](#). Since then, Astranis has scaled to around 250 people, and is in the process of kickstarting a new, 150,000 square foot factory, a historic building it is subleasing from ride-share giant Uber. The four satellites that will be launching next summer will be manufactured there.

Correction: The Falcon Heavy rocket launch will take place this summer, not this spring as originally stated.

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IMAGE CREDITS: ROCKET LAB

SPACE



Space Force tees up new 'responsive space' mission from Rocket Lab and True Anomaly

Aria Alamalhodaei — 4:10 PM PDT · April 11, 2024

Rocket Lab and True Anomaly will attempt to deliver and operate space hardware for the military under intentionally tight time frames, as part of the Space Force's push to solicit "tactically responsive" space capabilities from commercial companies.

Each company will design and build a satellite capable of rendezvousing with other spacecraft in orbit at close proximity, as well as command and control centers for the mission. As part of Rocket Lab's \$32 million contract, it will also launch the satellite with its Electron rocket. True Anomaly will

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partner with an unnamed “trusted commercial launch provider” for its ride under its own \$30 million contract, according to a statement.

Notably, True Anomaly said it would also “leverage \$30 million of internal private capital” for the mission, so it will spend a combined \$60 million to stand up its Jackal for this contract.

The target for spacecraft delivery under the contract, called Victus Haze, is fall 2025. Once the spacecraft have been built, the two companies will enter successive phases, including a “hot standby” phase where they must essentially remain ready to respond to the Department of Defense’s notice to manifest the satellite and launch. Once in orbit, Rocket Lab and True Anomaly must rapidly commission and ready their spacecraft for operations — with each other.

If all goes to plan, Rocket Lab’s Pioneer satellite will conduct the so-called rendezvous and proximity operations with True Anomaly’s Jackal spacecraft.

The new contracts are similar to those awarded to Firefly and Millennium Space in 2022, which saw Millennium deliver the satellite for launch by Firefly. That mission, [called Victus Nox](#), was executed last September. Under that mission, the two companies had to integrate the payload and ready the rocket in less than 58 hours; then, Firefly was given just 24 hours to launch.

While exact timelines for the Victus Haze mission were not disclosed by either Rocket Lab or True Anomaly, the former company did say in a statement that the mission “will improve ... processes and timelines.”

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SpaceX faces two new lawsuits alleging safety-related retaliation

Aria Alamalhodaie

- Jul 30, 2025



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The new mission also includes a handful of additional, ambitious requirements, like on-orbit spacecraft maneuvering, which is meant to simulate a real-life rendezvous with an adversary satellite.

“We recognize the significant opportunity to leverage the commercial space industry’s innovations to counter China as America’s pacing threat,” Space Systems Command program executive officer Col. Bryon McClain said in a statement. “The United States has the most innovative space industry in the world. Victus Haze will demonstrate, under operationally realistic conditions, our ability to respond to irresponsible behavior on orbit.”

Topics: [Rocket Lab](#) [Space](#) [Space Force](#)

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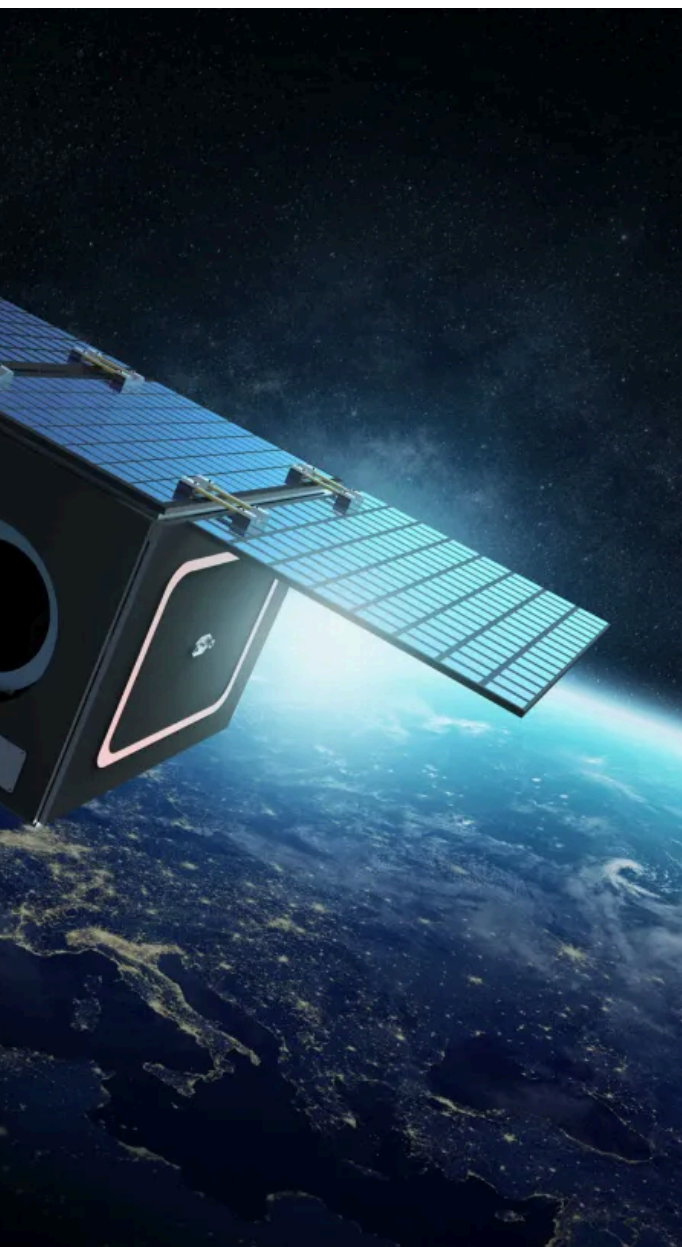
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The CEO of Boeing's satellite maker, Millennium Space, has quietly left the company

Aria Alamalhodaie — 8:59 AM PDT · August 28, 2024

IMAGE CREDITS: [MILLENNIUM SPACE SYSTEMS](#)

Update: The day after TechCrunch published this story, [Firefly Space announced that Jason Kim is joining the company as CEO.](#)

Boeing's satellite maker [Millennium Space Systems](#) will soon have a new CEO. Jason Kim, the executive who held the position for nearly four years, has departed the company, TechCrunch has learned.

Boeing acquired Millennium Space Systems in 2018. Since that point, the company has scored [mega-deals with the U.S. Department of Defense](#) to build satellites to help warfighters track missiles and other threats. Millennium also successfully executed a "responsive space" mission for the U.S. Space Force; [that mission, called Victus Nox](#), sought to establish a new record for the time it takes to put a defense payload into orbit.

Millennium and its partner for the mission, Firefly Space, accomplished just that: Last September, the two firms were able to integrate the Millennium-built satellite with Firefly's launch vehicle after 58 hours. The satellite was operational just 37 hours after launch.

"We are grateful to Jason for his leadership, growing the portfolio and evolving the company to a workforce of nearly 1,000, and wish him the best in the next phase of his career," a Millennium spokesperson said in a comment. "We anticipate announcing a CEO in the near term who can carry forward Millennium Space Systems' spirit and culture of rapid delivery. Millennium Space Systems' mission has not changed, and the team continues their unwavering focus on customer commitments."

Kim did not immediately respond to TechCrunch's request for comment. Kim was not a founder of Millennium Space Systems but was appointed around two years after Boeing acquired the company. Its founder and former CEO, Stan Dubyn, led the company for 17 years. Prior to Millennium, Kim held leadership positions at Raytheon's space

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division and Northrop Grumman. He also served in the U.S. Air Force.

The move comes at a time of uncertainty for Boeing's space businesses more broadly. The aerospace giant has come under the microscope for its bungled Starliner mission, which experienced technical problems shortly before docking with the International Space Station, [leading NASA officials to decide that the spacecraft should return to Earth without astronauts onboard](#). However, the reason for Kim's departure is unclear. There are other executive vacancies in the industry right now — including at Firefly, whose CEO departed just days after [Payload Space published a report](#) alleging he was under investigation at the company.

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